

Aynura Erejepbaeva

Prof. Aldrich and Bouba

What's in Your Toolbox?

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Learning to Look

We visited the Hood Museum of Art as part of the class on Thursday. We were a small group of students, and everyone gathered on time in the lobby of the museum at around 10:05 a.m. Last year, the museum served rather as a 'dining hall' for most Dartmouth students, in the sense that they came just to have some food, and I know they wouldn't necessarily visit the arts. I'm glad we took the time to collectively look at them. Most classes happen to be indoors and in a classroom-based environment, which is sometimes boring. What we did was like getting out of a cage and discovering the unknown on the other side of campus.

We first looked at one artwork that contained some official poses of people stitched into small frames. The first step was to describe what we saw—objectively. Maybe family members had their pictures taken for a passport or some sort of documentation? Why do some of them have professional attire while others don't? Why do some of them look confident while others look confused? When we read the label, it didn't surprise me that those belonged to immigrant documentation and that the artist had moved from Mexico to the U.S. What I noticed was that everyone was eager to share what they saw, and everyone's perspectives differed. I thought they must be a family, while Aiden, my classmate, shared that it might be a time frame of the same person. The interpretation stage showed me how imaginative each one of us is and raised questions about the subjectivity of art.

Later on, we described even more artworks and even drew one through hearing. It made me think about various ways we could appreciate art: if we pause and think about what a piece of art in front of our eyes truly means, if we don't immediately jump into the information label, then we can truly understand the artist. We tend to take a lot of pictures when we visit museums so that we can store them in our visual memory. The activity we did truly pushed us to "take on an adventure with the art" and not rush to fill our phone galleries with pictures.

Looking ahead, I would like to visit as many museums as I can in the U.S. After all, 'high culture' activities, such as visiting museums and exposing ourselves to different mediums of art, aren't as costly as they used to be. Indeed, the Hood Museum of Art is free for students, and I believe Dartmouth students should take advantage of that. There are even free museum trips organized by various clubs on campus, and I remember visiting the Museum of Fine Arts in Boston through the Dartmouth Museum Club. A museum visit can teach a piece of history, free the soul that's tangled in routine, and tell a story that's often challenging to deliver with words.